Building Approval-Based Workflow Automation in a Zoho Creator Application

Case Study 13

Aim

To build an approval-based workflow in Zoho Creator that automatically routes requests to an approver and updates their status.

Objective

- Understand workflows and approval processes in Zoho Creator.
- Design a Leave Request application with approval logic.
- Configure approval, rejection and notification actions.
- Test the workflow with different user roles.

Selected Application

Employee Leave Management App – employees submit leave requests; the manager approves or rejects them; the employee is notified of the result.

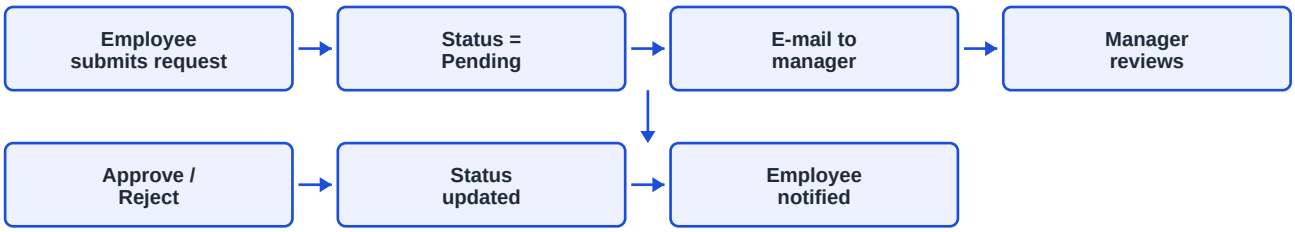
Workflow Concepts

Concept	Description
Workflow	Set of automated actions triggered by an event, such as form submission or field update
Trigger	Event that starts a workflow: on create, on edit, on schedule, or on approval
Condition	Rule that decides whether an action runs (e.g., Days > 3)
Action	Task performed: send e-mail, update record, create record, call function
Approval	Process in which a designated user reviews a record and approves or rejects it

Form Design: Leave Request

Field	Type	Purpose
Employee Name	Single line / user lookup	Requester
Leave Type	Dropdown	Casual, Sick, Earned
From Date / To Date	Date	Leave period
Number of Days	Formula / number	Calculated from the dates
Reason	Multi-line	Justification
Manager Email	Email	Approver
Status	Dropdown / system field	Pending, Approved, Rejected
Manager Comments	Multi-line	Reason for decision

Approval Process Flow



Procedure

1. Create the “Leave Request” form with the fields above.
2. Open the **Workflow** section and create a new workflow for the form, triggered **On Create** → **On success**.
3. Set the Status field to “Pending” automatically and send a notification e-mail to the manager.
4. Configure the **approval** step: assign the manager as approver, define Approve and Reject actions, and enable comments.
5. On **approval**: set Status = Approved and send a confirmation e-mail to the employee.
6. On **rejection**: set Status = Rejected, record the manager's comments and e-mail the employee.
7. Add a condition for longer leaves (for example, more than 5 days) so that the request is sent to a second-level approver.
8. Test with an employee account and a manager account; verify status changes, e-mails and the report view.

Sample Deluge Script – Notify Manager on Submission

```
// Workflow: on create of Leave_Request -> On success
input.Status = "Pending";
sendmail
[
    from : zoho.adminuserid
    to : input.Manager_Email
    subject : "Leave request from " + input.Employee_Name
    message : "Leave type: " + input.Leave_Type + ", Days: " + input.Number_of_Days
]
```

Menu labels and the exact approval configuration screens differ by Zoho Creator version; the script is illustrative of the logic used.

Test Scenarios

Scenario	Expected Result
Employee submits valid request	Status = Pending; manager receives e-mail
Manager approves	Status = Approved; employee notified
Manager rejects with comment	Status = Rejected; comment visible; employee notified
Request with more than 5 days	Routed to second-level approver
Employee tries to edit after approval	Edit blocked by permissions

Observations

- Manual follow-up and paperwork were replaced by automatic routing.
- Each decision is stored with status and comments, giving a clear audit trail.
- Conditions make the workflow flexible for different business rules.

Results

- An approval-based Leave Management workflow was created.
- Notifications and status updates occurred automatically.
- The process became faster, transparent and traceable.

Conclusion

Approval workflows in Zoho Creator automate routine business processes without heavy coding. They reduce delays, ensure accountability and provide a pattern that can be reused for purchase requests, expense claims and many other approvals.